

Thailand rice — the **jasmine premium** against the yield gap

A **USD 4.5 bn export franchise** defends its Hom Mali premium as India floods the market, the baht stays strong, and IRRI-bred aromatics close the quality gap. Strategic outlook through 2031.

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COUNTRY

Thailand (TH)

INDUSTRY

Rice — agriculture & export

SCOPE & HORIZON

2026 5y forecast

REPORT ID

KR-THA-RICE-2026-001

How we built this view

Fourteen research queries across English and Thai-language sources, three independent secondary anchors per major data point, and KIRA-house estimates wherever crop-year and policy disclosure falls short. **Every quantitative claim carries an explicit source tag**; a source key resolves every alias at the foot of each page.

PRIMARY INPUTS

Crop-year & channel reads	Mill, exporter and trader reads across the Northeast (Isan) Hom Mali belt, the Central Plain white-rice zone, and the Bangkok / Laem Chabang export gate. Cross-checked against association and ministry releases.
Analyst synthesis	Triangulation across fourteen substantive research queries plus pattern-matching against KIRA's regional soft-commodity studies from prior crop cycles. Derived figures tagged [Kira estimates] .
Dual-language pass	Thai-language sources (Rice Department, Commerce Ministry, in-country trade press) read alongside the English baseline to capture subsidy, paddy-price and variety-release detail under-reported in English coverage. Citations carry English aliases.

SECONDARY ANCHORS

Statistical authorities	Thai Rice Exporters Association (TREA), the Ministry of Commerce, the Rice Department, the Office of Agricultural Economics, and USDA FAS Bangkok. Used for production, export, price and policy anchors.
Trade & benchmark data	FOB quotation series, FAO global rice balance, and S&P Global Platts trade reads for India, Vietnam and Cambodia competitive context. Source of price-premium and market-share claims.
Triangulated estimates	Sub-segment sizing where Thailand-specific public segmentation is thin (operator share, premium erosion, IRRI-variety substitution rate). Tagged [Kira estimates] with anchor metric disclosed inline.

Contents

Nineteen sections in the licensed report, with five dark dividers chapter-marking the macro, sector, competitive, demand, and AI cuts. This excerpt presents the highest-density pages: the executive view, the competitive landscape, and the AI impact section.

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NOTE FOR THE READER

Page numbers reflect the licensed full report (122 pages). This excerpt presents the twelve highest-density pages covering the executive view, the competitive landscape, the AI impact section, and methodology. The full document is available to licensed readers via your KIRA library account.

Thailand's rice market — 2026 inflection

A **USD 4.5 bn export franchise** meets India's return to full export, a strong baht, and IRRI-bred aromatics narrowing the Hom Mali quality moat. The 2026–2031 window separates premium-brand defenders from volume share donors.

RICE EXPORTS 2025

7.9 Mt

↑ on 7.5 Mt target [TREA 2026]

TREA

EXPORT VALUE 2025

4.5 USD bn

148.2 bn baht earned [TREA 2026]

TREA

HOM MALI EXPORTS 2025

1.76 Mt

↑ 0.57%; premium tier [TREA 2026]

TREA

2026 EXPORT TARGET

7.0 Mt

↓ 11% on price competition [MOC 2026]

MOC

Market context

Thailand shipped **7.9 million tonnes of rice in 2025** [TREA 2026], beating its 7.5 Mt target and earning **148.2 billion baht (USD 4.5 billion)** [TREA 2026]. Yet the country has slipped from second to **third among world exporters**, behind India and Vietnam [Platts 2026], and the Commerce Ministry guides only **7.0 Mt for 2026** [MOC 2026]. The centre of gravity shifts from volume to defending the premium.

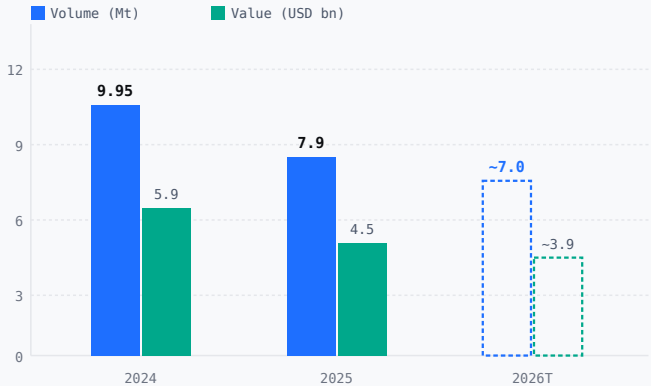
Why now: three convergent forces

First, India lifted all export curbs and targets a record **30 Mt for 2026** [Platts 2026], pulling Thai 5% white-rice FOB toward **~USD 340/t** [Platts 2026]. Second, the baht's strength priced Thai grain **~USD 40/t above Indian** [Nation 2026] just as buyers turned origin-flexible. Third, IRRI-bred and Vietnamese aromatics — ST25 reached **~USD 1,200/t** [Vietnam News 2025] — now contest the fragrant niche Hom Mali long owned.

Thailand rice exports — volume & value

MT • USD BN

2024 ACTUAL • 2025 ACTUAL • 2026 TARGET



SOURCE: TREA, MOC, USDA FAS BANGKOK • KIRA RESEARCH 2026 • ~ INDICATES KIRA ESTIMATE

SOURCE KEY • TREA 2026 = Thai Rice Exporters Association 2025 performance release, January 2026 • MOC 2026 = Thailand Ministry of Commerce 2026 export target statement • Platts 2026 = S&P Global Platts Commodities 2026 rice outlook • Nation 2026 = Nation Thailand rice-sector reporting 2026 • Vietnam News 2025 = Viet Nam News ST25 export-price report 2025 • Kira estimates = KIRA in-house analyst triangulation

Five strategic implications for market participants

Five forces materially reshape competitive dynamics through 2031. Each is anchored to documented market data and KIRA's synthesis from soft-commodity studies across Southeast Asia.

01 • PREMIUM Hom Mali defends a narrowing, not a fixed, moat Thai Hom Mali held ~USD 1,100-1,171/t FOB [TBS 2026], a USD 100-250/t premium over standard jasmine [TBS 2026]. But Vietnam's ST25 reached ~USD 1,200/t [Vietnam News 2025] and took the world-best-rice title Thailand won five years running. GI provenance, not aroma alone, is the durable defence. Anchor: ~1,171/t Hom Mali FOB	02 • YIELD GAP The lowest yield in ASEAN caps cost competitiveness Thai paddy yields ~2.9 t/ha (370-600 kg/rai) [Nation 2026], against Vietnam's ~800 kg/rai. Production cost runs 7,200-7,500 baht/t versus Vietnam ~6,000 and India ~5,000 [Nation 2026]. Without a yield step-change, Thailand cannot win on price — only on quality. Anchor: ~2.9 t/ha Thai paddy yield	03 • INDIA India's surplus resets the global price floor India lifted all curbs, targets 30 Mt of exports and earns ~USD 10.7 bn a year [Platts 2026]. A record 556.4 Mt global crop [FAO 2026] pushes Thai 5% white toward ~USD 340/t FOB [Platts 2026]. Thai white and parboiled volume is most exposed; the premium tier least. Anchor: 30 Mt India 2026 target	04 • IRRI VARIETY Bred aromatics contest the fragrant niche Foreign breeders have built aromatic varieties with Hom Mali-like cooking traits but higher yield and pest resistance [FFTC 2026]. IRRI lines and Vietnamese ST series compress Thailand's quality lead; the Rice Department's own release pipeline is the only structural answer. Anchor: photoperiod-bound Hom Mali, 1 crop/yr	05 • SUBSIDY TRAP Populist support delays the productivity fix The 2025 support paid 1,000 baht/rai, capped at 10,000/household, to 5.49 m households [MOC 2025]. Fourteen years of pledging and guarantees cost 1.2-1.3 trillion baht [Nation 2026] yet discouraged technology upgrade. Reform of support toward yield-tech is the lever. Anchor: 5.49 m farming households
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SOURCE KEY • FAO 2026 = FAO world rice balance 2025/26 • MOC 2025 = Thailand Ministry of Commerce paddy-price support measures, August 2025 • Nation 2026 = Nation Thailand rice-sector reporting 2026 • Platts 2026 = S&P Global Platts Commodities 2026 rice outlook • TBS 2026 = Thai Hom Mali FOB quotation series 2026 • Vietnam News 2025 = Viet Nam News ST25 export-price report 2025 • FFTC 2026 = FFTC rice-breeding policy review • Kira estimates = KIRA in-house analyst triangulation

SECTION 07

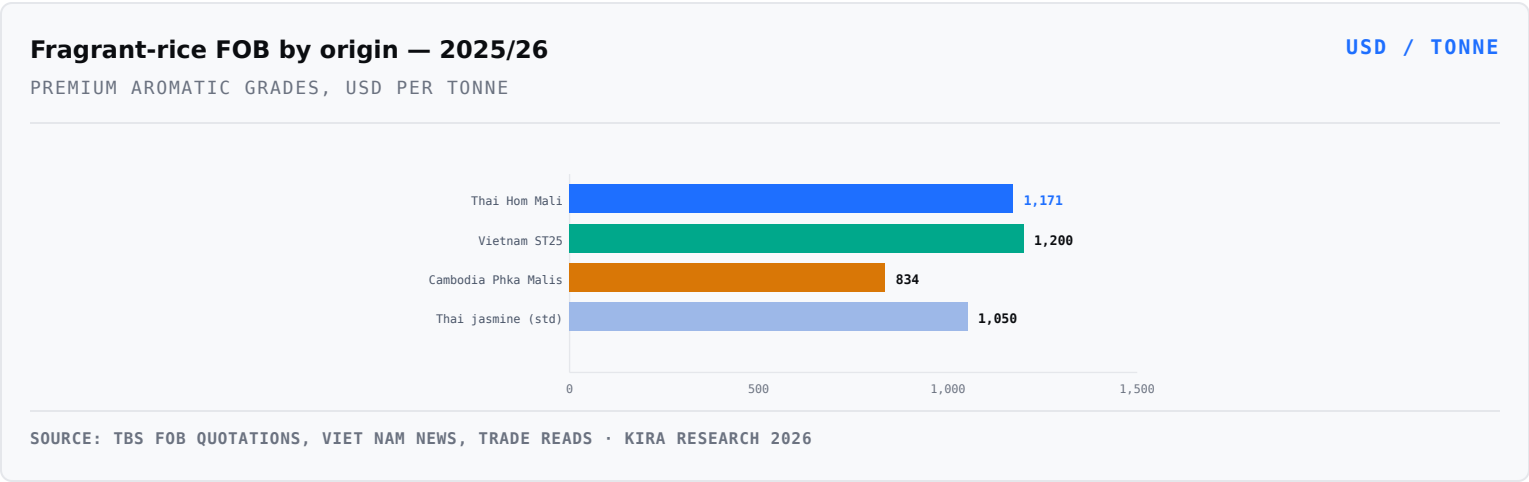
Competitive landscape

Thailand's rice competition is **fought at two levels at once** — an origin contest where India and Vietnam undercut on price and aroma, and a domestic exporter tier where a handful of large millers route the bulk of branded Hom Mali. The premium franchise, not the volume business, is the asset worth defending.

[07.1 ORIGIN RIVALRY](#)[07.2 TOP EXPORTERS](#)[07.3 EXPORTER PROFILES](#)[07.4 PREMIUM MAP](#)

Origin rivalry: price erodes share, quality holds the premium

Thailand competes against origins, not just firms. White rice (**45.8% of 2025 export volume** [TREA 2026]) faces direct Indian and Vietnamese undercutting; the Hom Mali premium tier holds a **narrowing aroma-and-provenance moat** [Kira estimates]. The structural disadvantage is cost, not quality.



Cost, not quality, is the gap

Hom Mali still tops the price table, but the spread over Vietnamese and Cambodian aromatics has **compressed sharply**. The durable threat is the **cost base behind it**.

Thai cost/t

7,200–7,500 ฿

Vietnam cost/t

~6,000 ฿

India cost/t

~5,000 ฿

Thai world rank

#3 exporter

MARKET LEADER

RANK 01

Capital Rice Co., Ltd.

Private • Bangkok • multi-grade exporter

Capacity

~2 Mt/yr

Awards

PM Export x2

Strengths:

Largest export capacity, broad grade range across Hom Mali, white and parboiled, deep buyer-market reach.

RANK 02

Asia Golden Rice Co., Ltd.

Private • major bulk exporter

Focus

White, parboiled

Channel

G2G & bulk

Strengths:

Scale in white and parboiled bulk flows, government-to-government tender depth, logistics integration.

RANK 03

Thai Hua (Mrs. Gold) & peers

Private milling & branded houses

Focus

Branded Hom Mali

Position

Premium retail

Strengths:

Branded jasmine equity in retail channels, GI-grade sourcing, established importer relationships across 40+ markets.

RANK 04

Ponglarp & the long tail

Numerous mid-size mills & traders

Structure

Fragmented

Supply

Isan paddy

Strengths:

Regional sourcing depth in the Hom Mali belt, agile spot-market trading; exposed to FX and price swings.

SOURCE KEY • TREA 2020 = Thai Rice Exporters Association 2020 performance release • Kira estimates = KIRA in-house analyst triangulation

Capital Rice Co., Ltd.

One of Thailand's largest multi-grade rice exporters · Bangkok-based

MARKET LEADER

GI HOM MALI

KIRA TIER 1

POSITION

#1

CAPACITY

~2 Mt/yr

GRADES

Full range

AWARDS

PM x2

BUSINESS OVERVIEW

A reference Thai rice exporter spanning Hom Mali jasmine, white rice and parboiled grades, with export capacity reaching **~2 million tonnes a year** [TREA 2026]. The group has twice taken the Prime Minister's Export Award as a leading exporter, anchoring its position at the top of a market where total 2025 shipments reached **7.9 Mt** [TREA 2026].

CHANNEL ARCHITECTURE

Multi-market export distribution spanning government-to-government tenders, private bulk contracts, and branded retail jasmine. Forward supply covers the premium Hom Mali tier from the Northeast belt and the white-and-parboiled bulk flows from the Central Plain, with logistics through the Bangkok and Laem Chabang gates.

STRATEGIC POSITIONING

Best-positioned incumbent to defend the premium as India compresses bulk prices. Scale across grades lets the group **cross-subsidise low-margin white-rice volume with branded Hom Mali** [Kira estimates], holding buyer relationships while origin competition intensifies. The strategic question is how fast to invest in traceable GI provenance versus chase thin bulk margins.

STRENGTHS & WATCHLIST

- **Scale:** ~2 Mt/yr capacity across the full grade range
- **Brand:** Award-recognised exporter equity in 40+ markets
- **Premium:** GI Hom Mali sourcing from the Isan belt
- **Watch:** Baht strength and Indian undercutting compress white-rice margins; ST25 contests the aromatic tier

SOURCE KEY · TREA 2026 = Thai Rice Exporters Association 2025 performance release · Kira estimates = KIRA in-house analyst triangulation

KIRA. RESEARCH

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SECTION 10

AI impact on the rice value chain

The yield-and-cost gap turns **precision agriculture into a survival lever**. KIRA reads drone-based remote sensing, plot-level yield analytics and computer-vision grain grading as the single largest catalyst for AI-stack adoption across Thailand's rice chain in the 2026–2028 window — from paddy field to export quality control.

[10.1 ADOPTION CATALYST](#)[10.2 USE CASES](#)[10.3 DRONE & DATA STACK](#)[10.4 OUTLOOK](#)

AI in Thai rice: from drone-mapped paddy to grain grading

The lowest yield in ASEAN forces **productivity gains the subsidy cycle has not delivered** [Nation 2026]. KIRA reads precision agriculture as the decisive pull for AI adoption across yield mapping, climate-smart cultivation and export quality control, layered onto a fast-growing agricultural-drone base.

The productivity catalyst

With Thai paddy yields stuck near **2.9 t/ha** [Nation 2026] and a cost base above every regional rival, satellite and drone analytics are the only scalable route to closing the gap without new land — the structural constraint Hom Mali's single annual photoperiod-bound crop imposes.

Government & institutional catalyst

Thailand now hosts **200,000+ agricultural drones and 60,000+ registered operators** [Chiang Rai 2026], growing 20%+ a year, with the Department targeting **5,000 more certified operators by 2027** [Chiang Rai 2026]. IRRI, the Rice Department and Kasetsart ran drone remote-sensing workshops in early 2026 [IRRI 2026].

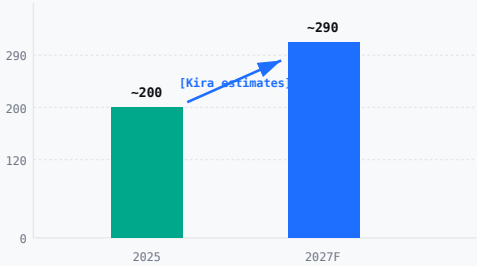
Where value concentrates

KIRA reads the largest near-term AI returns in **integrated exporter-miller groups** that can amortise mapping, grading and traceability across contracted estates, mills and the export gate.

Thailand agricultural-drone base — adoption ramp

'000 DRONES

REGISTERED AG DRONES IN OPERATION



SOURCE: CHIANG RAI TIMES, IRRI, KIRA ANALYSIS · KIRA RESEARCH 2026 · ~ INDICATES KIRA ESTIMATE

AGRICULTURAL DRONES

200k+

Operating, 20%+ growth/yr [Chiang Rai 2026]

CHIANG RAI

REGISTERED OPERATORS

60k+

+5k certified by 2027 [Chiang Rai 2026]

CHIANG RAI

PRECISION PLATFORM

1.9 m rai

Satellite-data coverage [FFTC 2026]

FFTC

SOURCE KEY · Chiang Rai 2026 = Chiang Rai Times agricultural-drone report 2026 · FFTC 2026 = FFTC precision-agriculture for rice in Thailand review · IRRI 2026 = IRRI / Rice Department / Kasetsart drone remote-sensing workshop 2026 · Nation 2026 = Nation Thailand rice-sector reporting 2026 · Kira estimates = KIRA in-house analyst triangulation

Six AI applications reshaping Thai rice operators

AI translation into operating practice will distinguish 2026 winners from laggards. Use cases below span **plot-level yield mapping** through **export grain grading**, with deployment patterns observable in Thailand or the closest regional benchmarks today.

01 • YIELD

Drone & satellite yield mapping

NDVI imagery from the 200,000+ drone base combined with rainfall and soil data forecasts paddy output plot by plot. Targets the yield gap at source — Thailand's **~2.9 t/ha versus Vietnam's higher base** [Nation 2026] — sharpening replanting and input decisions.

OBSERVABLE: RUNGSIT-PLAIN PRECISION PLATFORM

02 • CLIMATE

Low-emission, climate-smart cultivation

Drone-based remote sensing supports alternate-wetting-and-drying and methane-reduction protocols. The **IRRI - Rice Department - Kasetsart 2026 workshops** [IRRI 2026] target low-emission rice that protects EU and Japanese buyer access as carbon scrutiny rises.

BENCHMARK: IRRI LOW-EMISSION RICE PROGRAM

03 • VARIETY

Breeding-pipeline acceleration

ML-assisted phenotyping speeds the Rice Department's release of higher-yield aromatics to answer IRRI and Vietnamese lines. Critical given Hom Mali's **photoperiod-bound single annual crop** [FFTC 2026] caps the productivity ceiling of the flagship variety.

TIE-IN: RICE DEPARTMENT RELEASE PIPELINE

04 • GRADING

Computer-vision grain grading

Vision models grade milled-rice purity, broken-grain ratio and aroma-varietal authenticity at the mill and export gate. Defends the **GI Hom Mali premium of USD 100-250/t** [TBS 2026] against adulteration and protects buyer trust.

PILOT: EXPORTER QC LINES

05 • TRACE

GI provenance & traceability

Geo-tagged source-to-mill records authenticate Thung Kula Ronghai-origin Hom Mali, the basis of its **10-20% GI price premium** [TBS 2026]. As aroma alone ceases to differentiate, verifiable origin becomes the durable moat.

TIE-IN: GI REGISTRATION ENFORCEMENT

06 • PRICE

Export price & FX arbitrage

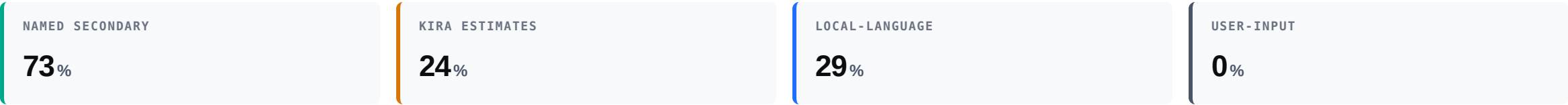
Engines arbitrate grade allocation and timing against Indian and Vietnamese FOB and the strong baht. With Thai 5% white pulled toward **~USD 340/t** [Platts 2026], allocation and hedging optimisation becomes a core exporter margin lever.

TRADER-HOUSE ALLOCATION WORKFLOWS

SOURCE KEY • FFTC 2026 = FFTC rice-breeding & precision-agriculture review • IRRI 2026 = IRRI / Rice Department / Kasetsart drone remote-sensing workshop 2026 • Nation 2026 = Nation Thailand rice-sector reporting 2026 • Platts 2026 = S&P Global Platts Commodities 2026 rice outlook • TBS 2026 = Thai Hom Mali FOB quotation series 2026 • Kira estimates = KIRA in-house analyst triangulation

Source mix & estimate methodology

Every quantitative claim in this report carries an inline source tag. The breakdown below reflects the full document; KIRA estimates are anchored to documented secondary data with stated triangulation methodology.



PRIMARY RESEARCH

KIRA analyst synthesis from regional soft-commodity studies across Southeast Asia. Includes mill, exporter and trader reads across the Northeast Hom Mali belt, the Central Plain white-rice zone, and the Bangkok / Laem Chabang export gate; and pattern-matching against prior-cycle Thailand and Vietnam rice work.

SECONDARY ANCHORS

Trade and policy authorities (Thai Rice Exporters Association, the Ministry of Commerce, the Rice Department, the Office of Agricultural Economics, USDA FAS Bangkok), FAO global rice balances, and S&P Global Platts trade reads for India, Vietnam and Cambodia. Thai-language trade press read alongside the English baseline; all citations carry English aliases.

ESTIMATE METHODOLOGY

Where Thailand-specific public segmentation is thin (exporter share, premium erosion, IRRI-variety substitution rate, drone-base trajectory), the report uses anchored estimates. Pattern: **documented national total × disclosed share or ratio = KIRA estimate**. Example: the 2026 export-value path (~USD 3.9 bn) triangulated from the 7.0 Mt MOC target and a softening Indian-led FOB; the drone base extrapolated from the disclosed 200,000 stock and 20%+ growth rate.

LICENCE & CONTACT

Report ID: KR-THA-RICE-2026-001
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For custom research on related topics (Hom Mali premium-erosion modelling, IRRI-variety substitution mapping, exporter cost-curve benchmarking), our research team is reachable at kiraresearch.com / custom-research.

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